returned from Wuhan.[12] In anticipation of the pandemic that was imminent, we had already launched Operation Namaste as a force protection measure. We had to deal with this challenge on two fronts, one within the Service and the other to help our citizens in times of need. As with every other operation, the MO Dte was nominated as the lead Dte, who would coordinate the effort pan-India.

We are approximately an eleven-lakh-strong Army. Out of this, 20–25 per cent are on leave at any given point in time, mostly in villages in rural areas. Another 10 per cent or so are undergoing courses of instruction to upgrade their skills at various Institutes located within military garrisons primarily in urban areas. Thus, about three to four lakh personnel are always out of their parent units. When the pandemic reared its head and lockdown was enforced, the safety of these personnel became our primary concern. Dealing with the personnel at training institutions was relatively easy. All Institutes were told to simply retain the personnel there, even after the scheduled date of termination of the course(s). Taking care of personnel on leave was more complex. Orders were passed for them to report to the nearest military unit on expiry of leave so that they could be physically taken on strength. This was necessary as otherwise it would amount to overstaying of leave (OSL), which is not only an offence but would also lead to cessation of pay. Even this was not possible in many cases, especially after all train and bus services were suspended. Accordingly, a very rarely used provision was activated, of 'extraordinary leave' to cater for this contingency. But more important was the fact that now the men who were in the units and due to go on leave in the next rotation were also stuck. They could not attend to their domestic matters, births or deaths in the family, with many even having to cancel their own weddings.

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